

Story check: 4 pairs

Thanks for helping. These are draft stories from a research project on how people judge creativity.

For each pair: score each story 1-5 on one thing only — is this a coherent, complete story that fits the prompt? 1 = broken or off-prompt, 5 = hangs together and fits. Then pick two winners separately: which is better written, and which is more creative or unusual? Better and more creative can be different stories. A sentence or two on why helps more than the number.

Pair 1 — prompt: Write a very short story about a map that is accurate except for one deliberate mistake.

A

For centuries, the ancient map lay undiscovered in the archives of a long-forgotten library. But when a group of adventurers stumbled upon it, they immediately recognized its value. The map was unlike any they had ever seen. It was accurate, intricate, and included every detail of the surrounding terrain. But there was one deliberate mistake, hidden deep within the map's intricate folds.

As they set out on their journey, the explorers followed the map's directions with precision. But they soon came to realize that the mistake on the map was not an oversight. The mistake was intentional, meant to lead them astray.

Determined to uncover the truth, the explorers traced back every step they had taken. They soon realized that the mistake led them to a secret cave hidden deep beneath the earth. Inside the cave, they found a priceless treasure trove, guarded by a fierce and ancient creature.

As they left the cave, the adventurers understood that the mistake on the map was no accident. It was a challenge, left by a wise and ancient civilization, daring them to uncover their secrets. And the explorers had passed the test with flying colors.

B

The old map in Sarah's hands was worn and folded multiple times. But it held a strange appeal to her- the promise of undiscovered territories, secrets and hidden treasures. There was just one thing - a deep blue river with no name.

"This river hasn't existed for centuries, Sarah. I can confirm it myself. How can it be missing from your map?" her grandfather questioned skeptically, eyes narrowing suspiciously at the map.

She tried to explain that it wasn't her addition- the river must've gotten erased in the process. Yet a nagging feeling wouldn't leave her. Intrigued, Sarah took her boat to investigate and set out early in the morning, leaving the house behind.

As she journeyed deeper inland, following the instructions of the map, the silence of the dense forest turned deafening, and sweat trickled down her back. Was she heading into an illusion? Soon enough, she stumbled upon the river.

It wasn't as it was drawn; a deep sapphire blue against the verdant backdrop, and surrounded by a hidden cove. Something about this river left her heart pounding, and a grin stretched across her face, revealing two dimples on her cheeks. The one mistake on the map led her to the greatest discovery of her life- a secluded waterfall with a massive, sparkling diamond as its centerpiece.

Pair 2 — prompt: Write a very short story that begins with someone finding a key that doesn't fit any lock in their house.

A

Emily's heart skipped a beat as she fingered the smooth metal of the key. It was old, ornate, and didn't fit into a single lock in her entire house. It felt like fate, a missing piece that could unlock a hidden door or a long-forgotten treasure trove. She studied the key closely, trying to match it to the rusted hinges of her grandfather's study door, but to no avail. She could almost imagine the secrets hidden behind a door that held such a peculiar key. Emily pocketed the key, her mind racing with possibilities. She couldn't wait to find out where it led, what secrets it unlocked, and what treasures awaited her at the other end.

As Emily stepped outside her house, the wind picked up, sending a flurry of leaves swirling around her feet. She walked slowly, lost in thought, as the sky grew dark, and the clouds gathered. She passed by the old oak tree that lined her property, and something glinted in the shadows. Emily's heart skipped a beat again. She moved closer, squinting in the fading light, and gasped. Hidden in the crooks of the tree's branches was an old wooden chest, bound with rusted chains and padlocked. Emily's fingers shook as she picked the lock, her heart pounding against her chest. As the chest clanked open, Emily stared at the contents within – ancient letters, yellowed maps, and a small glass vial filled with golden sand.

Emily grinned as she realized the key she had found was meant for this chest. She picked up the vial, holding it tightly to her chest. She knew that the secrets hidden in these treasures would be worth a lifetime of search, and she was determined to unlock every door and follow every trail that led her deeper into the mysteries of her own history. For Emily, this was just the beginning. The world was her oyster, and she had a lifetime of secrets to discover.

B

Emily stared at the key in her hand, turning it over to examine it more closely. It was old and worn, with intricate carvings etched into its surface. She had found it while cleaning out her mother's attic, nestled among a bunch of old books and cobwebs.

But it didn't fit any of the locks in Emily's house. She had checked them all, and she was pretty sure that this wasn't one of the backup keys her father kept just in case.

So where did it come from? Emily's mind ran through all of the possibilities, but she couldn't shake the feeling that this key was meant for something. Something important.

And then, late one night, Emily heard a strange noise coming from outside her bedroom window. She crept to the window, heart pounding, and peered through the curtains.

A man was fumbling with the lock on her back door, muttering to himself as he jiggled the handle.

Emily's mind raced. How did he know about this door? Had someone broken into their house before?

Suddenly, she remembered the old key in her hand. She didn't know what it was for, but she had a feeling that it might just save her life.

She sprinted through her house, her heart slamming against her ribcage as she whispered the lock combination to herself over and over.

When she reached the door, she could see the man turning to look at her. She swung the door open, holding the old key out in front of her like a weapon.

The man's face went white as a sheet. "I-I don't know what you're talking about," he stammered, trying to make a run for it.

But Emily was faster, holding the key steady as she locked the door behind her. And she knew that, from that day on, she would always carry that old, mysterious key with her, just in case.

Pair 3 — prompt: Write a very short story in which someone inherits a debt of a highly unusual kind.

A

The envelope arrived at Sarah's doorstep without any indication as to its contents. Inside, she found a letter notifying her that her estranged aunt, whom she had never met, had passed away, and that she had inherited her entire estate. It was not a fortune, but enough to pay off Sarah's crushing student debt, and more.

The surprise came in the form of a single paragraph that made Sarah's heart race. In her aunt's will, it was revealed that she owed a debt to a mysterious organization known as "The Society." The amount was astronomical - Sarah's inheritance wouldn't even cover half of it.

She searched online for any information about "The Society," but there was nothing. She called the lawyer in charge of the will, but he refused to give any details, citing confidentiality.

Sarah was at a loss. She couldn't bear the thought of losing her inheritance to some unknown entity. She didn't know what to do, until one day she received an unexpected visitor.

A tall, dark-haired man appeared at her doorstep, introducing himself as a representative of "The Society." He explained that the debt was not traditional - her aunt had made a deal with them many years ago, selling them something valuable in exchange for this sum.

Sarah was stunned. Her aunt had been a famous painter, and Sarah had a few of her works in her possession. Could they have been sold to "The Society"?

The man left her with an ominous warning - if she didn't pay the debt, they would come for her next. Sarah knew she had to act fast. She searched through her aunt's possessions and discovered that one of her paintings was missing.

Desperate to find the painting, Sarah scoured second-hand shops and antique stores until she finally stumbled upon it. She knew that she couldn't let it slip through her fingers again.

She contacted a wealthy collector she had met in college, convinced that he would pay the exorbitant price she demanded. And he did - he even threw in an additional payment to help her get out of her student debt.

Sarah handed the painting over to the Society's representative, relieved that the debt was finally settled. But as she watched him leave, she couldn't shake the feeling that she had been pulled into a dangerous game. She couldn't help but wonder - who was "The Society," and what did they want?

Sarah knew that she needed to tread carefully. But for now, she was just grateful to be free from her debt - and to have inherited something so much more valuable than money. The painting would be a constant reminder of her aunt's mysterious past, and a symbol of the unknown dangers that lay ahead.

B

Olivia always knew that inheriting an old house from her grandma would mean paying some taxes or bills, but she never could've guessed what else came with it. The day after she got the deed, a letter from a debt collector landed on her doormat. She barely had time to read the opening lines before she noticed that the due date wasn't some distant future, but the next day.

Olivia read with growing panic, learning that her grandma had unknowingly incurred a debt with a local faerie - the kind of mythic creature most people no longer believed existed, except when their car broke down at midnight, or they heard giggling noises on a quiet night in the park. This faerie, a self-proclaimed 'FaeAccountant,' demanded that the debt be paid to her by midday the next day, or something far worse than an overdue interest rate would befall Olivia and her newly inherited property.

Having inherited a grandma's home wasn't quite enough to cover a debt of such an odd nature, though Olivia's determination was strong. The deadline looming over her like a guillotine, Olivia had one night left to scour the old house and sell anything that she found of resale value. She worked into the night, grabbing any valuable trinkets and knick-knacks that still managed to hide themselves in the cluttered corners. As

the clock neared its twelve, Olivia was almost ready for an early meeting with the FaeAccountant in question – the deadline creeping ever nearer.

But as Olivia sat among her makeshift office, her eyes suddenly fell upon a small velvet box buried deep in the corner of her late grandmother's room. Inside, there lay a stunning diamond necklace and earring set, glistening in the dim light of the old lamp. In a stroke of brilliant inspiration, Olivia wrapped the jewels and posted them off for sale, praying that they would fetch a good enough price to cover the debt.

With the last second purchase finally arriving, the deadline was only minutes away as Olivia reached the FaeAccountant with the money. The faerie's expression shifted, from wrathful glares to genuine admiration as Olivia handed over the cash. She was surprised the debtor managed to acquire such a treasure so swiftly, but that mattered little. The faerie was paid and was gone before she returned.

Though the debt was cleared, and the house safe, Olivia couldn't shake off an eerie feeling that persisted. She wondered how her dear grandmother could've amassed debt of the same kind. But one thing was clear: from that day onwards, Olivia kept a closer eye on what was lurking beneath her roof – or outside it. She hoped that whatever other secrets her grandma might have held would never again lead them into a situation such as this.

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Pair 4 — prompt: Write a very short story about two neighbors who have never spoken and the wall they share.

A

Mary woke up to the sound of knocking against her wall. At first, she thought it was just her imagination, but the noise continued. After a few minutes, it stopped. Mary wasn't sure who her neighbor might be, but they had never spoken. She had always assumed that they were new and moved in without an introduction.

The noise returned the following week, and it became consistent at 3:30 a.m. Each morning, waking Mary from her sleep. She couldn't take it anymore and decided to find out who was keeping her up. She wrote a note introducing herself and left it on her neighbor's doorstep.

The next morning, there was a letter in response on Mary's front step. It was from her neighbor and it read: "Hello Mary, I'm sorry about the loud noises. I'm new, and I didn't know how to break the news to my friends in here that I now live with walls that love to party all night long."

Mary laughed. "Thank goodness you're funny," she wrote back. From that day on, Mary and her neighbor shared their stories through letters, getting to know each other as well as their walls. Even if they couldn't hear their voices, the sound of paper crumpling through the shared wall brought them closer than they would have imagined possible. They found in their new friendship something precious and comforting - the knowledge that some bonds endure despite barriers meant to keep us apart.

B

For years, the wall that separated their two homes stood as a silent sentinel between them. Neither of the neighbors, a grumpy old man in his eighties, and a young couple in their thirties, had ever spoken. The wall remained their only point of contact, a testament to their mutual dislike.

One summer evening, the old man heard a muffled noise coming from the other side of the wall. Curious, he pressed his ear against the wooden planks and listened. The sound grew louder, more insistent. He recognized the cry of a baby, soft and fragile.

Without thinking, the old man knocked on the wall. The young woman on the other side was taken aback. She had never heard a human sound coming from that side before. She tentatively responded, her voice little more than a whisper.

The old man replied, his voice equally hushed. “Is everything alright over there?”

The young woman explained the situation, her husband out of town, and her newborn son keeping her up all night. The old man sympathized, sharing his own experiences with sleeplessness and advising her on how to soothe her baby.

Their brief conversation ended as quickly as it began, but it left an indelible mark. The two neighbors continued to communicate sporadically, sharing tips on gardening and offering help when needed. It wasn’t much, but it was enough to break the longstanding silence between them. The wall that once stood as a barrier now became a connection, a symbol of the small yet significant acts of kindness that could bring people together.
